

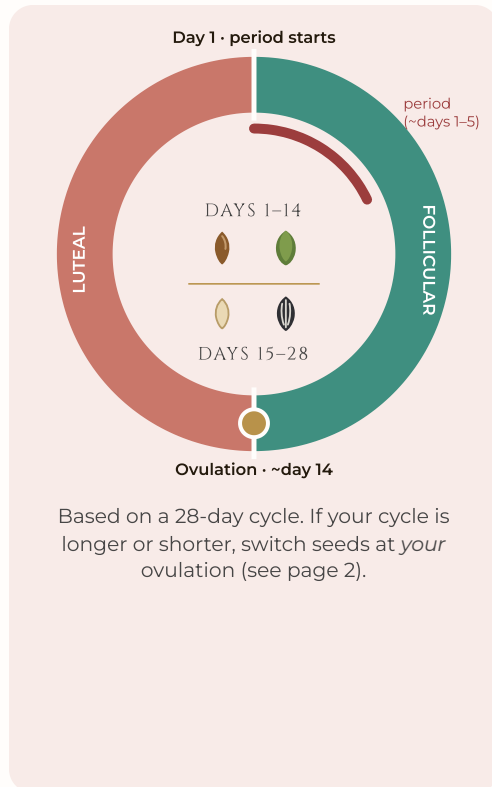


SEED CYCLING

for hormone harmony & cycle health

PELVIC HEALTH
PATIENT HANDOUT

Seed cycling is a simple food-based practice: you eat **two specific pairs of seeds**, switching pairs at ovulation to match the two main phases of your menstrual cycle. It is a gentle, low-cost way to add fibre, healthy fats and key minerals to your day, and to start paying closer attention to your cycle.



PHASE 1 · DAY 1 OF YOUR PERIOD → OVULATION

FOLLICULAR PHASE

1 Tbsp flaxseed
freshly ground

1 Tbsp pumpkin seeds
raw pepitas

- **The traditional idea:** support healthy estrogen levels as it rises toward ovulation.
- **Flax** is the richest food source of *lignans* (plant compounds that interact with estrogen), plus soluble fibre and omega-3 ALA.
- **Pumpkin seeds** are rich in zinc and magnesium.

PHASE 2 · OVULATION → YOUR NEXT PERIOD

LUTEAL PHASE

1 Tbsp sesame seeds
or tahini

1 Tbsp sunflower seeds
raw, unsalted

- **The traditional idea:** support progesterone, which should be the dominant hormone after ovulation.
- **Sesame** provides lignans, zinc, calcium and healthy fats.
- **Sunflower seeds** are an excellent source of vitamin E, selenium and magnesium.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS *an honest look*

- **Seed cycling itself hasn't been properly studied.** No quality clinical trials have tested the phase-by-phase schedule, and there's no evidence yet that switching seeds at ovulation changes hormone levels in a meaningful way.
- **The seeds themselves have some promising research.** In a small study of 18 women, adding ground flaxseed daily was linked with fewer cycles without ovulation and a slightly longer luteal phase¹. Flax lignans have weak estrogen-like and estrogen-balancing effects in the body^{1,2}.
- **The nutrients matter.** Zinc, magnesium, vitamin E and omega-3 fats have each been studied for period pain and PMS, mostly as supplements, with modest but encouraging results^{3,4}. Seeds are a whole-food way to include them.

The bottom line: seed cycling is safe for most people, affordable and nourishing, and a helpful daily ritual for tuning in to your cycle. Think of it as *one supportive piece* of your plan, not a treatment on its own for heavy, painful, irregular or absent periods. Those deserve a proper assessment.

HOW TO START *simple steps*

- 1 **Start today** with the pair for the phase you're in. No need to wait for your period.
- 2 **Aim for 1 Tbsp of each seed daily** (2 Tbsp total), all at once or spread across meals.
- 3 **Grind your flaxseed**, as whole flax passes through undigested (grinding the others is optional). Grind a week at a time and **keep it in the fridge**.
- 4 **Choose raw, unsalted seeds**. Light toasting is fine.
- 5 **Switch at ovulation** (or ~day 14 if unsure). Signs include stretchy "egg-white" cervical mucus, a rise in basal body temperature or a positive ovulation test.
- 6 **Stay consistent for about 3 cycles** and track cramps, mood, bloating, energy, bowel and bladder symptoms.

NO PERIOD OR IRREGULAR?

If your cycles are irregular or absent (for example in **perimenopause, menopause, postpartum or while breastfeeding**), many people use the **moon cycle** as a steady 29-day rhythm:



New moon → full moon

Flax + pumpkin



Full moon → new moon

Sesame + sunflower

On hormonal birth control? Your natural cycle is paused or changed, so the "cycling" part doesn't really apply, but the seeds are still a nourishing daily habit.

No period for 3+ months (and not pregnant, breastfeeding or in menopause)? Please talk to your doctor or nurse practitioner.

EASY WAYS TO EAT YOUR SEEDS

SMOOTHIES

Blend in with fruit, greens and yogurt.

BREAKFAST BOWLS

Stir into oatmeal, yogurt or chia pudding.

SALAD TOPPER

Toasted seeds add crunch to salads and soups.

SEED BUTTERS

Tahini or sunflower butter on toast or apples.

BAKING

Add ground seeds to muffins or pancakes.

PREP AHEAD

Keep a jar of each blend in the fridge.

SEED CYCLING ENERGY BITES *no-bake*

Makes about 12 · keeps 1 week in the fridge or 3 months frozen

- 1 cup large-flake rolled oats
- ½ cup nut or seed butter (see variations)
- ½ cup honey or maple syrup
- ¼ cup each of your **two phase seeds** (ground)
- ¼ cup dark chocolate chips (optional)
- 1 tsp vanilla, pinch of cinnamon and salt

Method: Mix everything in a bowl. Chill 20 minutes, then roll into 1-inch balls. **3 bites ≈ 1 Tbsp of each seed.**

Phase 1 bites (follicular)

Ground flax + pumpkin seeds, with almond or peanut butter. Try adding a little orange zest.

Phase 2 bites (luteal)

Sesame + sunflower seeds, with tahini or sunflower seed butter. Dark chocolate and a pinch of cardamom work well.

Tip: make both batches and label them so switching is easy.

YOUR CYCLE & YOUR PELVIC FLOOR

Hormone shifts across your cycle can affect **pelvic pain, bladder urgency and leaking, bowel habits and tissue sensitivity**, often most noticeably just before and during your period.

The fibre in these seeds (especially flax) supports **softer, regular bowel movements**, meaning less straining on your pelvic floor. Pair seed cycling with your pelvic health exercises, movement, sleep and stress care.

SAFETY & WHEN TO CHECK IN

- **Allergies:** sesame is a common allergen. Skip any seed you react to.
- **Add fibre slowly** over 1–2 weeks and drink plenty of water.
- **Check with your provider first** if you have a hormone-sensitive condition, take blood thinners or are pregnant.
- **See a doctor** for very heavy bleeding, pain that disrupts daily life, or bleeding between periods or after sex.



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This handout is general education and does not replace individual medical advice. Seed cycling is a complementary practice and is not intended to diagnose or treat any condition. Please ask your physiotherapist if you have questions.